



The manifestation of rythme(rhyme and poetic metre) in Hafsidi prophetic praise

- taking the poems of Chihab Eddine Ekossantini as a model -

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Abstract ;

In this briefresearch, we examine one of the aspects of "the rhythmic formation" in Hafsidi poetry, which is the rhythm, besides the poetic language and artistic images. For this, we study a poetry Blog of an ancient Algerian poet of Madih. This subject is meant to summon the prophetic praise for its sacred messages, and for its unique rhythmic style. Therefore, we studied the poetry collection of "Jana Eljanatain" to Chihab Eddine Ekossantini, who mated artistic language to rhythmic style of Religious Madih.

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1. *Introduction*

The interplay between the measured cadence of meter, the echo of rhyme, and the inner resonance of words generates a musical quality that exists both within and beyond the poem. When a poet or reader juxtaposes the rhythm of meter with the tonal character of the words, they are essentially comparing the abstract melody inherent in metrical and rhymed patterns with the partial, nuanced melodies carried by the vocabulary itself. This contrast reveals the way meter contributes to the poem's structural integrity. The musicality of poetry, therefore, arises from the dynamic tension between the language's rhythmic architecture and the semantic and phonetic properties of its words, all shaped by the harmony between abstract metrical resonance and actual linguistic material. Variations in meter and rhyme strongly influence this process.

In panegyric poetry—particularly that of the Hafsid era—the rhythm is charged with intricate connections between outward, structural beats and inward, melodic inflections, beginning with the meter and extending to the tonal shifts within individual lines. The resonance of rhyme and meter plays a decisive role in shaping this external music. The present study seeks to illuminate such often-overlooked dimensions within the selected corpus, assessing how they contribute to the overall unity of the panegyric. Specifically, it asks:

Which artistic and literary resources did the poet draw upon to craft the musical elements of praise poetry? And to what degree do these rhythmic frameworks foster the poem's coherence and organic integration?

2. *Between Rhythm and Poetic Music*

3. *2.1 The Nature of Rhythm*

Rhythm is a universal attribute that permeates all art forms—it is equally at home in music, verse, prose, dance, and even the visual arts. It forms the foundational principle upon which every artistic or literary composition rests. Creators employ rhythm through three principal strategies: repetition, alternation, and linkage (Mohamed, 2009, p. 25). Philosophically, rhythm embodies the patterned motion underlying life itself, manifesting in the cyclical order of the cosmos: day and night, dawn and dusk, seasonal change, and the perpetual alternation of light and shadow (Mertad, 2009, p. 200).

Because scholars have interpreted rhythm in diverse ways, its definitions have been far from uniform. Although the concept has long been part of aesthetic theory, the absence of a single, precise definition has caused its meaning to shift over time (Mohamed, 2009, p. 23). Some researchers even claim that no single theory can encompass the totality of rhythm, a semantic drift that has, in their view,

“weakened its technical precision” (Tripoli, 1991, p. 7).

The concept has broadened from its early association with “marking tunes and harmonizing sounds in singing” toward a more inclusive sense of the patterned distribution of spoken elements in literary discourse. It has thus become a central aesthetic principle shared by all the arts, governing the recurrence and placement of stresses, pauses, phonetic clusters, and structural or lexical forms that together create a sense of movement (Mohamed, 2009, pp. 26–27). In linguistic terms, rhythm can mean “the harmonious arrangement of sounds and their scansion in singing” (Mohamed, 2009, p. 24) or “the orderly recurrence resulting from the distribution of strong and weak beats, stresses, and other temporal elements within a verse or musical phrase” (Mohamed, 2009, p. 24).

In poetry, rhythm has been described as “a musical arrangement composed of unequal durations, representing the sonic dimension of verse” (Arabic Language Academy, 1979). It entails the measured repetition of similar components—a quality that, by its very nature, defines poetic rhythm and marks it as one of the most pervasive features of poetic language. As the French scholar Pierre Giraud observed, prosody and versification occupy “the most cyclical domains of statistical linguistics,” since their purpose is to determine how sound

patterns achieve precise, recurring structures (Fattouh, 1999, p. 95).

4. 2.2 *The Artistic Value of Rhythm and Poetic Music*

By following the ebb and flow of rhythmic variation, one can trace the inner journey of the poet’s creative self—its efforts to enrich musicality and diversify metrical forms—and grasp why poetry commands a special status over prose. In Arabic literary tradition, poetic expression has displayed “astonishing rhythmic abundance.” While the unchanging desert environment and material conditions of life left their mark on other arts, poetic rhythm emerged full of energy and variety, as though resisting monotony through song (Dib, 1974, p. 43). Rhythm is not only a core structural feature of poetry but also one of its most effective artistic tools. It is a principal marker distinguishing poetry from prose, though by no means the only one (Zayed, 2008, p. 154).

Despite differences among critics about its essence, meanings, and scope, there is general agreement on rhythm’s central role and aesthetic potency. It is regarded as “the defining property of poetry,” the force that imposes order upon a flux of harmonious sounds (Mohamed, 2009, p. 31). Functionally, rhythm is far from being a mere didactic device; rather, it performs an intrinsic aesthetic role within the fabric of verse. A poem cannot truly be called poetry

unless it engages rhythm in an artistically meaningful way (Mertad, 2009, p. 214).

When rhythm permeates a poem's structure, the linguistic material itself acquires a texture and vitality absent from ordinary speech (Fattouh, 1999, p. 96). Poetry, then, is a mode of discourse that reaches deep into the self through harmonious arrangement—a prerequisite for its existence. Since poetry is at once rhythm and metaphor, any speech devoid of these elements fails to qualify as verse. Rhythm is both a structural pillar and an artistic hallmark, capable of carrying meaning, stirring emotion, and exerting profound influence. It is not a superficial embellishment but one of the most compelling tools for expressing the inexpressible—those depths of feeling and thought that mere words cannot capture (Zayed, 2008, p. 154).

Rhythm's value lies not only in its musical appeal or psychological effects but also in its capacity to suggest meaning beyond the literal. If art seeks to evoke what lies beneath the surface, rhythm becomes its privileged medium, a language of tension and emotion rooted in sound harmony rather than the mechanical arrangement of syllables. Were rhythm nothing more than a rigid framework for ordering words, the authors of grammar books would be counted among the finest poets. Instead, rhythm brings with it qualitative depth, aesthetic energy, and exceptional

expressive force (Waqad, 2003/2004, p. 13; Al-Ayashi, 1976, p. 69).

Some critics have intuitively grasped this suggestive power. For them, the music of poetry sharpens attention, animates words with new life, and makes their meanings vividly tangible. It lends language an air of grandeur and refinement, enabling it to reach the heart upon hearing. This musicality encourages repeated reading and recitation (Anis, 2010, p. 17). In any artistic work—fundamentally a sequence of sounds bearing meaning—the auditory layer is central to its aesthetic effect. Melody thus embodies a form of logic that language alone cannot dissect; nature reveals it through sound, and the soul responds with affection and longing.

2.3 Rhythm and Poetry... Poetry and Song

The music of poetry is “the wellspring of its enchantment, the secret of its beauty, and the quality that sets it apart from other modes of expression.” It is the first thing the ear perceives, seizing the listener's attention and reaching into the heart (Bin Yahya, p. 2). It creates a melody that satisfies the ear and resonates with innate human instincts. As Ibn Rashīq al-Qayrawani observed, poetry stripped of musicality is poetry stripped of its garment.

No spoken language rivals music's ability to convey emotion, particularly when wedded to verse. Poetry and music arose

together, each animating the other, enhancing beauty and deepening imaginative scope (Al-Alaf, 1963, p. 90). Their bond is one of mutual formation, rooted in the primal rhythms of nature. Music draws its patterns from this original pulse, as does poetry; they remain linked by an intimate rhythmic kinship that unites more than it divides (Mertad, 2009, p. 209).

The musicality of poetry, together with its melodic devices, shapes the psychological atmosphere of the poem, coloring its imagery and articulating its emotional experience (Qadri, n.d., p. 144). Rhythm emerges in the act of creation itself, inseparable from the moment a poetic concept becomes a written text. It is misguided to suggest that rhythm is chosen mechanically to suit a poem's subject; rather, it arises from the poet's creative impulse at the moment of composition (Mertad, 2009, pp. 205–211).

Poetry's identity is inseparable from rhythm, which is why, for centuries, Arabs defined verse as measured and rhymed speech governed by an orderly musical framework (Waqad, 2003/2004, p. 2). In its traditional form, poetry consists of rhymed lines shaped by metrical weight, producing an aesthetic impression on the soul. When the rhythmic form complements the idea, it magnifies the poem's beauty (Diab, 2012, pp. 5–8). Poets did not consciously select rhythms from a menu; instead, their verses emerged under the pressure of strong

emotion, becoming works of enduring artistic value, “woven with tears of loyalty and deep affection” (Mertad, 2009, p. 208).

Thus, the two sides of poetic beauty—structural rhythm and expressive meaning—are intimately connected. Both depend on an effective vocal performance that transforms sound into semantic resonance, uniting rhythm and poetry at every level so that verse becomes, in essence, the music of thought.

Although critics and scholars hold varying perspectives on the nature, implications, and conceptualizations of rhythm, they concur on its significance and its aesthetic and expressive value in grasping the poetic phenomenon. Rhythm is regarded as “the fundamental property of poetry,” serving to organize the poetic process by bringing unity to what would otherwise be a disorderly flow of homogeneous sounds (Mohamed, 2009, p. 31).

Within its functional domain, rhythm is not simply a monotonous auditory feature serving didactic purposes; rather, it possesses “an aesthetic function that is integrated into the overall poetic system. Its role in poetic composition is not secondary—it is an essential component of poetry. No poem can truly claim the quality of poetry without engaging aesthetically with rhythm” (Mertad, 2009, p. 214).

Beyond being a defining element that distinguishes poetry from other literary

forms, “when the rhythmic structure permeates a work, the linguistic components of that work acquire a special quality absent from everyday language” (Fattouh, 1999, p. 96). Poetry is thus a form of discourse that penetrates deep into the self through harmonious structuring—an essential condition for its very existence. Poetry is rhythm and metaphor; without them, speech cannot be called poetry. Rhythm constitutes one of the core structural and artistic features that differentiate poetry, carrying its content and aiming to evoke emotion, stir feelings, and exert a profound influence. “Rhythm in poetry is not an external ornament added to it; it is a powerful means of suggestion and among the most effective tools for expressing the hidden depths of the soul, which mere words cannot convey. As such, it stands as one of the strongest and most impactful means of suggestion for touching the soul” (Zayed, 2008, p. 154). In the text, rhythm reflects its presence in the psyche during moments of unrest and emotional tension, engaging directly with the impulses that drive writing.

Rhythm should not be mistaken for “a mere source of musical pleasure or a response to psychological needs.” It holds an intrinsic value in the meanings it suggests. If art is an expressive evocation of meanings that transcend the literal, rhythm is one of the primary instruments for such expression. It is the language of tension and emotion, forming the foundation of poetry’s

musicality. It stands as one of poetry’s most crucial elements, grounded in harmony and the blending of sounds—not merely in quantitative arrangements of words. Otherwise, those who design educational curricula would be the most poetic of all. Instead, rhythm “has qualitative value, aesthetic energy, and exceptional expressive capacity, all of which significantly enrich poetry” (Waqad, 2003/2004, p. 13; Al-Ayashi, 1976, p. 69).

Some critics, albeit vaguely, have acknowledged this suggestive power of music in poetry. They observe that “the music of poetry heightens our attention, breathing life into words beyond their ordinary existence, and enabling us to perceive meanings as if they were visually embodied before us. It bestows grandeur and dignity upon speech, polishing and refining it so that its meanings reach the heart upon hearing. All of this inspires a desire to read, recite, and continually repeat the poem” (Anis, *The Music of Poetry*, 2010, p. 17). In an artistic work—fundamentally a sequence of sound conveying meaning—the auditory dimension draws the listener’s focus, forming part of its aesthetic and suggestive power. Melody represents a form of logic that language alone cannot fully capture; nature reveals it through tunes rather than analytical breakdown, thereby enchanting and captivating the soul.

2.4 Rhythm and Poetry... Poetry and Song

The music of poetry is “the source of its enchantment, the secret of its beauty, and the distinguishing aspect that sets it apart from other forms of expression. It is the first thing that reaches the ears, captivates them, and penetrates the heart, holding it in its grip for a long time” (Bin Yahya, p. 02). It creates a melody that delights the senses and harmonizes with natural human instincts. Indeed, the very essence of poetry is musical language—resonating with the soul and touching the heart. As Ibn Rashiq al-Qayrawani declared, “If poetry does not wear the robe of music, it is naked.”

No language in the world “can match music in expressing emotions—especially when it gives voice to poetry. Music and poetry came into being together; each breathes life and light into the other, enhancing mutual beauty and charm. They infuse each other with spirit and vigor, enriching meaning and imagination” (Al-Alaf, 1963, p. 90). Their relationship is thus one of shared creation and mutual growth.

It has been observed that music “draws its melodies from the rhythms of primal nature, just as poetry derives its rhythm from that same source. They are bound by a close rhythmic kinship that unites them far more than it separates them, bringing them closer rather than apart. Both share the same original natural rhythm” (Mertad, 2009, p. 209). Moreover, the music of poetry—along with the melodic techniques

it employs—“plays a vital role in shaping the psychological atmosphere that underlies the poetic image and expresses the emotional experience and the resulting thoughts and reactions” (Qadri, n.d., p. 144).

When rhythm emerges, it “integrates into the written text during the peak moment of creation, transforming a poetic idea into tangible form on the page. It is a mistake to claim that rhythm is selected solely according to the subject matter of a poem; such a claim does not warrant elevation to a general poetic principle” (Mertad, 2009, p. 211). “The choice of rhythm, a pivotal aspect of poetic structure, should not be determined externally; it must arise organically from the act of composition, from the poet’s creative impulse and innovative genius” (Mertad, 2009, p. 205). The features of rhythmic movement become “most apparent in poetry, which cannot exist without rhythm. The relationship between poetry and rhythm is thus intrinsic and inseparable. This is why, even in later times, Arabs defined poetry as measured and rhymed speech governed by a musical order that admits no disorder” (Waqad, 2003/2004, p. 02).

Poetry is a crafted form of language, composed of rhymed verses that “provide a distinct rhythmic sensation determined by the poem’s meter. It is an artistic construct that leaves a mark upon the soul, adorned with a structured linguistic form shaped to

produce a specific effect. When it aligns with the underlying idea, it heightens both beauty and brilliance” (Diab, 2012, pp. 05–08). These formal and stylistic features—including rhythmic form—vary from poet to poet, revealing the richness and magnificence of their art. “When such poems were created, their makers did not consciously choose the rhythm to be recited; they were driven by an outpouring of intense emotion, producing works that stand among the greatest masterpieces, woven with tears of loyalty and genuine love” (Mertad, 2009, p. 208).

Thus, the strong, inseparable bond between the two dimensions of poetic beauty is clear: both rely on resonant vocal performance to generate semantic resonance, beginning at the very point where rhythm intersects with poetry on every level—making poetry, in essence, the music of ideas.

3. Translation of the Poet Shihab al-Din al-Qasntini (829–899 AH)

3.1. Lineage and Birth

Shihab al-Din al-Qasntini’s full name is *Ahmad ibn Muhammad ibn Abdul Rahman ibn Muhammad ibn Abdul Rahman ibn Muhammad ibn Abdul Rahman al-Shihab Abu al-Abbas ibn Abu al-Qasim al-Humayri*, originally from Fes, born in Constantine, a resident of Tunis, a Moroccan Maliki jurist, and known by the title *al-Khallouf* (Daho, 2008, p. 11). His

family moved from Fes to Algeria, settling in Constantine—then under Hafsid rule—where he was born, hence his appellation *al-Qasntini*.

He was born in 829 AH (November 1425 CE). As a child, his father took him to Mecca, where he stayed for four years before moving with him to Jerusalem (Al-Jilali, 2010, p. 147).

3.2. Upbringing and Education

During his stay in Jerusalem, he formed close ties with leading Eastern scholars, notably Abu al-Qasim al-Nuwairi, under whose guidance he studied jurisprudence, language, and principles, deriving great benefit. He also learned Qur’anic readings and sciences from al-Shihab ibn Raslan, al-‘Izz al-Qudsi, and others (Al-Jilali, 2010, p. 147).

After his father’s death in Jerusalem in 859 AH / 1454 CE, the poet travelled to Cairo, where he engaged with its eminent scholars. There, he studied grammar, morphology, and logic with al-‘Izz Abd al-Salam al-Baghdadi (Al-Jilali, 2010, p. 147). He later learned Arabic under Ahmad al-Salawi al-Maghribi in Tunis. His exceptional memory was widely acknowledged—his teacher al-Salawi himself affirmed that he surpassed everyone he met in the Maghreb in memorization (Daho, 2008, p. 15).

These scholarly encounters profoundly enriched his learning and enabled him to

achieve his intellectual and literary ambitions. This is reflected in his celebrated work *Jannatayn* ("Paradise of Two Gardens"), also known as *Diwan al-Islam*. Settling in the Moroccan region, he gained wide renown among leading scholars for both his erudition and refined poetry. He was commissioned by Sultan al-Mas'ud ibn Othman, grandson of Abu Faris al-Hafsi, and visited Cairo several times.

During his pilgrimage in 877 AH / 1472 CE, he met Imam al-Sakhawi, engaging in literary discussions recorded in al-Sakhawi's historical work *al-Daw' al-Lami'* ("The Glowing Light") (Al-Jilali, 2010, p. 147). In 881 AH / 1476 CE, he returned to Tunis, where al-Sakhawi remarked: "He was honoured both during his stay and at his departure, and I bid him farewell" (Al-Qasntini, 2004, p. 17).

3.3. The Demise of a Star

There is some disagreement over the date of al-Qasntini's death, but the prevailing view—supported by Abdul Rahman al-Jilali, Hisham Bouqamra, and Dr. Arab Daho—is that he died in 899 AH. As noted, "Had the poet lived beyond 899 AH, we would expect to find in his works references to the significant events that shook Tunis, his place of residence, and other regions of the Islamic world; such references are absent from his poetry" (Al-Qasntini, 2004, p. 24).

4. Rhythmic Formation in Shihab al-Din al-Qasntini's Panegyrics

The musical structure is a core component in the formation of poetry, encompassing two intertwined elements: *external rhythm* and *internal rhythm*. These interact during the creative process and influence the reception of the poem across different contexts. The metrical and rhyming structure, together with the internal rhythm, are shaped within the meaning of the poem itself, surfacing fully in the reader's or listener's experience (Atiq, n.d., p. 5).

It is crucial to distinguish between the two: external rhythm is determined by meter and rhyme, whereas internal rhythm is governed by broader phonetic patterns beyond strict meter and rhyme (Bakar, 1983, p. 193). Both often work together to create aesthetic harmony. Relying solely on internal rhythm moves a text toward prose; relying only on external rhythm makes it mere versification. True poetry interlaces both, linking the opening and closing lines, maintaining thematic and rhythmic coherence throughout, and achieving aesthetic unity (Mortad, 2009, p. 213).

4.1. Meter

Classical scholars defined poetry as "measured and rhymed speech that conveys meaning." Meter preserves the sweetness of poetry, enhancing its appeal; without it, the ear would reject it and taste would falter (Ben Yahya, p. 2). It is a

central element of poetry and inherently includes rhyme (Al-Qairawani, 1981, p. 134).

Meter not only delights the ear but also conveys emotion and supports meaning. Its true value lies in creating a psychological resonance through established patterns of sound, rhythm, and emotional association (Iyad, 1968, p. 142). It distinguishes poetry from prose and serves as a critical measure of poetic craft. It has a “magnetic or electric” effect, transmitting joy and stirring emotion through balanced patterns of movement and pause (Qadri, n.d., p. 146).

Poetic music arises from meter and rhyme, and from deliberate word choice that fits a specific phonetic pattern. The rhythmic quality of a meter results from repeated phonetic units—arrangements of vowels and consonants—forming the metrical feet (Mahdawi, 2009, p. 111).

While no single meter is inherently tied to a specific emotion, poets may find some meters more adaptable to particular experiences. Changing life themes often encourage the use of more melodious meters (Qadri, n.d., p. 148). In Arabic, each

meter has distinctive qualities—for instance, the *Basit* meter, known for grandeur and public recitation, is especially suitable for praise poetry. Skilled poets instinctively select the most fitting meter (Mahdawi, 2009, p. 111).

Praise poetry, a highly formal genre, draws on the prestigious tradition of masters like Zuhayr, Hassan, Ka‘b, Jarir, al-Farazdaq, Dhul-Rummah, al-Buhturi, Abu Tammam, and al-Mutanabbi. Hafsid poets emulated these giants, adapting meters to suit their themes (Abdul Rahim, 2008, p. 591).

Traditional Algerian poetry aligns with broader Arabic poetic conventions, favouring meters such as *Kamil*, *Khafif*, *Basit*, *Tawil*, and *Wafir* (Al-Naja, 2003, p. 16). Shihab al-Din al-Qasntini remained faithful to these classical meters, often crafting long poems—sometimes over 500 verses—particularly in praise of the Prophet. For him, the length was both an artistic choice and a reflection of the magnitude of his subject. These works, blending historical narrative with poetic splendour, stand as Islamic epics for Arabic readers (Dhu, 2008, p. 136).

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Metrical Distribution in His Panegyrics

Meter	Number of Verses	Poem No.
Al-Wafir	140	01
Al-Basit	368	02
Al-Khafeef	214	03
Al-Basit	338	04
Al-Kamil	263	05
Al-Khafeef	350	06
Al-Saree'	233	07
Al-Kamil	15	08
Al-Kamil	100	09
Al-Tawil	564	10
Al-Khafeef	177	11
Al-Kamil	255	12
Al-Tawil	257	13
Al-Basit	331	14
Al-Basit	175	15
Al-Basit	190	16
Al-Tawil	328	17
Al-Tawil	379	18
Al-Wafir	105	19
Al-Basit	152	20
Al-Kamil	95	21
Al-Basit	88	22
Al-Khafeef	117	23
Al-Tawil	77	24
Al-Tawil	60	25
Al-Khafeef	206	26

Meter	Number of Verses	Poem No.
Al-Wafir	35	27
Al-Kamil (Mujaz)	222	28
Al-Saree'	60	29
Al-Basit	14	30
Al-Tawil	86	31
Al-Khafeef	122	32

From this table, it is clear that Ibn al-Khallouf favoured the longest and most resonant meters for his Prophet-praising poetry: eight poems in *Basit*, seven in *Tawil*, six each in *Kamil* and *Khafif*, three in *Wafir*, and two in *Saree'*. Out of a total of 6,116 lines, the *Tawil* meter alone accounts for 1,751 lines, or 28.62% of his output.

4.2. Poetic Meters

Analysis of the statistical distribution of poetic meters in the corpus reveals a distinct preference for expansive and weighty rhythmic patterns. The data shows:

- **Basit meter:** 1,656 lines (27.07%).
- **Khafif meter:** 1,186 lines (19.4%).
- **Kamil meter:** 950 lines (15.53%).
- **Sari' meter:** 293 lines (4.8%).
- **Wafir meter:** 280 lines (4.58%).

This sequence is not arbitrary—it reflects the poet’s deliberate inclination toward meters characterized by measured pacing and a dignified cadence, matching the temperament of the person being praised, whose qualities include composure, steadfastness, and deliberation. The exceptions are a few infrequently used forms, such as the Sari‘, the shortened Basit, and the truncated Kamil. The poet’s practice appears to be highly methodical: he likely composed these works after recalling, and perhaps emulating, other pieces in comparable meter and rhyme, particularly the masterful compositions that had reached the highest levels of creative refinement.

Shihab al-Din al-Qasantini’s choice of meters seems rooted in a belief that the rhythmic structure must correspond to the thematic gravity of the subject. In his view, these particular meters are ideal for solemn genres such as panegyric poetry because their extended line length and sustained rhythm leave a deeper and more enduring impression than shorter meters. They also serve as carriers of intense emotional expression—chief among them love for the Prophet, yearning for his intercession, and devotion to his noble family (Abdulrahim, 2008, pp. 593–597).

4.3 The Role of Rhyme

In Arabic poetics, rhyme is regarded as indispensable to the very definition of verse (Mohamed B., 2008/2009, p. 11). Without

it, neither the structural unity nor the musical cadence of a poem can be secured. Al-Qayrawani (1981, p. 101) notes that poetry is not truly such unless it contains both meter and rhyme. Al-Khalil ibn Ahmad al-Farahidi defined rhyme as the segment from the final letter of the verse to the first quiescent consonant that follows it, including the vowel preceding that consonant. This definition—more precise than Al-Akhfash’s simpler “last word of the verse”—highlights rhyme as an audible pattern that frames the poem, providing cohesion and guiding the listener’s ear toward an anticipated sound recurrence.

Rhyme functions like a melodic refrain, returning at fixed points to create pleasure through recognition, much as pauses punctuate a piece of music (Anis, 2010, p. 233). It is the second pillar of a poem’s external musicality, responsible for shaping the recurring tonal line and marking the close of each verse. While many lay listeners might not consciously identify the meter, they instinctively register and remember the rhyme, which has long been one of the clearest distinctions between poetry and prose (Abdulrahim, 2008, p. 597).

Prosodists, while differing in their definitions, unanimously insisted on rhyme’s necessity. They catalogued a range of flaws—such as forced rhymes or mismatched tones—that could diminish its musical and emotional effect. The finest rhymes are those organically required by

the meter and integrated seamlessly into the verse's overall rhythm. When executed well, the reader feels the verse was shaped expressly for its rhyme (Mohamed B., 2008/2009, p. 11).

Because rhyme naturally occurs at a poem's endpoint, it defines both the rhythmic and semantic closure of the line, giving each verse a degree of independence from those surrounding it (Mohamed M., 2009, p. 132). Though meter lays the rhythmic groundwork, the poem's aesthetic success depends on the interplay of multiple elements—of which rhyme remains central (El-Naga, 2003, p. 245). Its impact on the listener stems not only from sound repetition but also from semantic variation: rhymes that repeat the same word yet change its meaning tend to resonate more deeply than those that repeat both word and meaning (Fattouh, 1999, p. 128).

Rhyme's melodic aspect arises from the recurring pattern of consonants and vowels at the close of each verse, which remains consistent across the poem (Zayed, 2008, p. 158). For poets, rhyme is a discipline that counterbalances the flexibility of meter: it constrains the rhythm's flow, ensuring stability in form while enriching the musicality of the composition (Qadri, n.d., p. 156).

Technical Structure of Rhymes

Classical scholars analyzed rhyme in exhaustive detail, identifying its

constituent elements and permissible variations, as well as its defects. They distinguished six notable components:

1. **Wasl** (connection)
2. **Khurooj** (exit)
3. **Radf** (suffix)
4. **Ta'sis** (foundation)
5. **Dakhil** (intrusion)
6. **Rawi** (the principal rhyme letter)

Of these, the rawi is paramount—it is obligatory in traditional verse and is the primary identifier of a poem. A rhyme scheme that maintains the same rawi throughout is considered unified; one that changes is termed varied (El-Naga, 2003, p. 246).

Dr. Ibrahim Anis categorized rhyme letters by frequency of use:

- **Most frequent:** ر, ل, م, ن, ب, د, س, ع — remembered by “بَدَلْ عَنْ رَسْمٍ” (BADDIL ‘AN RASM).
- **Moderately frequent:** ق, ك, أ, ح, ي, ج — remembered by “قِي كَيْ أَحَجَّ” or “قِي حَجَّ أَيْكِي”.
- **Rare:** ض, ط, هـ, ت, ص, ث.
- **Very rare:** ذ, غ, خ, ش, ز (Abdulrahim, 2008, p. 599).

Shihab al-Din's rhyming practice aligns with Anis's classification. His preferred

endings come predominantly from the high-frequency group—especially *mīm*, *rā'*, *dāl*, and *lām*—followed by *sīn* and *'ayn*. The letter *nūn* appears only once, and just two letters (*tā'* and *hā'*) occur from the rare group. Entirely absent are the letters of the very rare group as well as the hamza, despite its traditional use in praise poetry. This omission may be due to hamza's perceived lack of melodic appeal. His emphasis on musical beauty led him to follow the precedent of earlier poets, avoiding letters that offered less resonance.

The result is a predominance of voiced consonants in his rhymes, with whispered sounds appearing in only six of the thirty-two poems (Dhou, 2008, p. 134).

In the collection, two other rhyming elements from the earlier classification also appear in his poetry: **radf** (a rhyme preceded by a specific letter) and **ta'sis** (a letter that begins the rhyme). These occur with notably different frequencies. **Radf** is present in seventeen (17) poems, most often with the letters *alif* (ا), *ya* (ي), and *waw* (و). Examples of *radf* with *alif* are found in the poet's verses.

From these rhymes containing *radf* and *ta'sis*, it is evident that Shihab al-Din al-Qasantini sought to convey his connection

to the Noble Prophet through extended, uninterrupted sounds, as if longing to gaze upon his radiant face and expressing this yearning with prolonged vocal stretches. These drawn-out sounds produce an effect that elevates

the listener's soul to realms of beauty, reflecting the sanctity and grace of the praised figure.

As for rhyme types, the previous examples illustrate both the sounds and the poet's variation between **unrestricted** and **restricted** rhymes. Unrestricted rhymes clearly dominate, appearing in twenty-six (26) poems—about 81%—while restricted rhymes occur in only six (6) poems, or 19%. This is significant given that Arabic eulogistic poetry generally favors unrestricted rhyme.

In some cases, the restricted rhyme appears without *radf* or *ta'sis*; in the third poem, the restricted rhyme includes *radf* with *alif*. This suggests that the poet aimed to present different types of restricted rhyme, except those combined with *ta'sis*. Overall, the variety in his rhymes approaches musical perfection, achieving both quality and clarity.

Table: Poems by Rhyme Type, Rawi, Radf, and Ta'sis

Poem	Rhyme Type	Rawi	Radf	Ta'sis
01	Unrestricted	ر	×	
02	Unrestricted	م		
03	Unrestricted	ل	×	
04	Unrestricted	ل	×	
05	Unrestricted	ل		
06	Unrestricted	ر	×	
07	Restricted	م	×	
08	Unrestricted	م		×
09	Restricted	م	×	
10	Unrestricted	م		
11	Restricted	ل	×	
12	Unrestricted	ع		
13	Unrestricted	ر		
14	Unrestricted	ت	×	
15	Unrestricted	هـ	×	
16	Unrestricted	ف		
17	Unrestricted	م		
18	Unrestricted	ع		×
19	Unrestricted	د	×	
20	Unrestricted	د	×	
21	Unrestricted	س	×	
22	Unrestricted	ت	×	
23	Unrestricted	ب	×	
24	Unrestricted	س		
25	Unrestricted	م		×
26	Unrestricted	د	×	
27	Unrestricted	ن		

Poem	Rhyme Type	Rawi	Radf	Ta'sis
28	Restricted	د		
29	Restricted	م	×	
30	Unrestricted	و		
31	Restricted	م		
32	Unrestricted	و	×	

5. CONCLUSION

The poet's use of meters and rhymes shows that in the field of praise poetry, he is a skilled eulogist, employing every technique that serves his purpose. His compositions carry the authentic musicality of classical Arabic verse—rooted in the deserts of the Arabian Peninsula, the courts of kings and caliphs, and the traditions of Sufi lodges. In this way, he embodies the evolution of Arabic poetry through its successive eras, culminating in his own distinctive brilliance.

From this overview, the following points emerge:

- Shihab al-Din's authenticity lies in his adherence to the meters and rhymes of earlier poets.
- For his prophetic praise, he selected the longest and most resonant meters: eight poems in *al-Basit*, seven in *al-Tawil*, six each in *al-Kamil* and *al-Khafif*, three in *al-Wafir*, and two in *al-Sari*.

- His poetry is rich in incorporation, quotation, repetition, and imitation, giving the impression that personal expression is secondary to emulation of the ancients. This approach, while technically accomplished, sometimes renders his own poetic voice less distinct.

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